

Open-faced focaccia with fava bean spread and tofu

This sandwich uses a wonderfully **mellow** but richly flavored spread made with fava beans. Fresh fava beans require a bit of work with the shelling and peeling, but they are worth it. If you are reading this and it's not late spring or summer, you probably won't be able to get fresh fava beans—or broad beans, as they are also called.

Out of season, look for frozen, peeled, and blanched fava beans in Asian or specialty/gourmet grocery stores.

You will have plenty of leftover spread here; save it for crostini or mix it into pasta or risotto. The tofu is **very simple**. Not all tofu needs to be marinated; in fact, some people are so used to it that they eat it plain, out of the box. In this recipe I recommend a cast-iron skillet to quickly brown the tofu. For even more flavor, grill the tofu, if you have the opportunity, as well as the focaccia.

3 pounds fava beans, shelled [1.5kg] (about
1 pound [500g] shelled beans)

½ cup extra virgin olive oil [125ml]

2 tablespoons lemon juice

½ sheet nori, toasted and crumbled*

1 teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 tablespoon chopped fresh basil plus 2 or 3
fresh leaves, thinly sliced

1 to 2 tablespoons vegetable oil

½ pound firm tofu, pressed of water, sliced
into 4 cutlets [250g]

1 piece of focaccia, approximately 6 x 4
inches [15 x 10cm], sliced horizontally into 2
thinner pieces

A few thinly shaved slices of pecorino
Romano cheese

4 to 6 fresh ripe tomato slices

Salt and freshly ground pepper (optional)

Extra virgin olive oil

1. Fill a bowl with ice water and set aside. **Cook** the shelled fava beans in a large saucepan of boiling water until just cooked through, 2 to 3 minutes; or 30 seconds to 1 minute if they are very small. Drain the beans and plunge into the ice bath. Drain again, then immediately peel the beans by pinching off a small piece of skin and popping the naked bean out.
2. In a food processor, **puree** the beans along with the olive oil, lemon juice, nori, salt, pepper, garlic, and 1 tablespoon chopped basil. Scrape down the sides a few times. Puree until very creamy. Pour into a bowl and set aside.
3. **Heat** the vegetable oil in a large cast-iron skillet over high heat. Add the tofu and quickly sear for about 2 minutes on each side, or until lightly browned.
4. Spread half of the fava bean puree over each cut side of focaccia. **Layer** on the tofu, Romano cheese, tomato slices, and remaining basil leaves, dividing evenly between the sandwiches. Season with a dusting of salt and pepper, if you desire. Drizzle on additional extra virgin olive oil for an authentic touch.

MAKES 2 OPEN-FACED SANDWICHES

*If the nori is not already toasted, place the sheet in a dry skillet over medium-low heat for 1 to 2 minutes, turning several times until the sheet turns a brighter green.

chef's tip

If fresh fava beans are not in season, substitute 1 pound [500g] frozen broad, fava, or lima beans and skip Step 1. Run the frozen beans under warm water just to thaw.